his part was surprised that a star like Khan would agree to do an ensemble drama, one with multiple characters with their own developed arcs. For Khan, if the script is engaging and challenging enough, then "why not?"

Khan admits he's always been a bit "jittery" before a work of his comes out. "In the past 10 years I have tried to do a diverse body of work," he says. "Being experimental can be dangerous but also exciting at the same time." But more than *Barzakh*'s quaintness, what's noteworthy is that it shows how art has the ability to bridge the gap, as it has done for decades, be it through music or dramas or writings. Says Khan, "Art can transport you to a different world. It does lend itself to an expression where you can say things in a sensitive way or in an insensitive way. As an artist, you have the choice and right on what you choose to portray." He lauds Shailaja Kejriwal's "guts" in supporting it. "I'd love to see her do more such things," he adds.

Whether *Barzakh* will rekindle Khan's rapport with the Indian audience remains to be seen, but he reveals he's maintained some of the ties he forged with his Indian colleagues and has followed their work. "Online platforms are that safe, diplomatic zone where one can see each other's work," he says, citing *The Family Man* as one show he enjoyed. Khan signs off assuring us that the wait to see him act again won't be long. Says Khan, "There's that famous dialogue *'Ab sailaab aayega, Madan Chopra'*—Now the flood will come, Madan Chopra; from Shah Rukh Khan in *Baazigar*. There are lots of things coming that people will be like *'thoda haule ho jaaye* (slow down a bit)'." ■

–Suhani Singh

CINEMA

RIDING HIGH

Kill is dancer-actor **Raghav Juyal**'s breakthrough film, a decade into his acting career

He's the villain who has the most lines, the darkly funny sort, and he draws the most laughs in *Kill*, the gory flick which unfolds on a train. Raghav Juyal had a bloody good time playing the menacing dacoit who instigates the chaos. Best known as a contestant on TV show *Dance India Dance*, then a choreographer on dance reality shows and finally as their funny host, Juyal decided in 2021 that he needed to get out of the comfortable terpsichorean zone and show his thespian skills."I left all of TV's pampering and ego behind, and put all my energy into acting," says Juyal. After his much-lauded performance in *Kill*, Juyal will be seen in the ZEE5 web series *Gyaarah Gyaarah*, an official adaptation of the popular K-drama *Signal*, which releases on August 9.

Hollywood's had a tradition of dancer-actors, but in Hindi cinema they are few and far between. It makes Juyal an anomaly. Even if he's had dance-centric films like *Street Dancer* and *ABCD 2* to his credit, he was eager to carve a niche as an actor in other genres. A self-taught dancer, Juyal realised that acting wouldn't be as easy a skill to pick up. He cites watching co-actor Vijay Raaz and realising "I am unable to reach this level". He started classes with actor-coach Saurabh Sachdeva. "He opened a channel and I tapped into something else within me...the vulnerability and the experiences that have shaped me," says Juyal.

To understand the psyche of killers, **Juyal** (below, in pic) watched true-crime documentaries and read articles



Five years of training emboldened Juyal enough so that some of his improvised lines in *Kill* were incorporated by writer-director Nikhil Nagesh Bhat. To play Fani, he picked up a Bihari dialect and watched true-crime documentaries and read articles to understand the psyche of hardened killers. "References are dangerous for actors," he says, "You lose your individuality. Locking myself in a room, becoming all dark, I didn't need to do this." Juyal's portrayal connects because amidst the immorality and carnage he is able to show a young man trying to get out of his father's shadow and express his ambition.

Kill is a game-changer for Juyal but it has come a decade after his first acting credit–*Sonali Cable* (2014). Juyal kept doing a film or two but some of his projects didn't see the light of day or get enough attention. "I told Saurabh Sir, you have said acting is doing, but when will acting is releasing happen," he recalls. With *Gyaarah Gyaarah* releasing soon, the rough patch is ending. Juyal is both excited and nervous. Originally set in Punjab, the ZEE5 series was shifted to his homeland, Uttarakhand, and it's the first time he'll speak in the Dehraduni dialect on screen. ■

-Suhani Singh